

This call intends to support initiatives towards flexible careers for research managers and career diversification of R&I talents towards research management. Actions should create joint virtual and non-virtual training programmes and curricula for research managers and prepare the road to certification and accreditation. Actions should take measures to realise equal opportunities for access to training programmes for staff from across the entire ERA, including from regions with lower R&I intensity.

The call addresses also support for virtual and non-virtual networks of research managers from public research performing and funding organisations at European level, as well as cross-border European operational networks (existing or new), complementing and coordinating existing national initiatives. Focus could be put on equal access for staff to such networks and exchanges, building capacity in regions and institutions of lower R&I intensity.

HORIZON-WIDERA-2024-ERA-01-04: Strengthening researchers' skills for better careers – leveraging the European Competence Framework for Researchers

Specific conditions	
<i>Expected EU contribution per project</i>	The Commission estimates that an EU contribution of around EUR 0.50 million would allow these outcomes to be addressed appropriately. Nonetheless, this does not preclude submission and selection of a proposal requesting different amounts.
<i>Indicative budget</i>	The total indicative budget for the topic is EUR 0.50 million.
<i>Type of Action</i>	Coordination and Support Actions

Expected Outcome: Projects are expected to contribute to the following outcomes:

- Researchers at all career stages equipped with a comprehensive set of transversal skills based on the European Competence Framework for Researchers (ResearchComp), to foster more open and inter-sectoral research careers, and a better recognition of the researcher profession;
- Coordination and exchange of best practices between Higher Education Institutions, research institutions, and other training providers for the improvement of research and transversal skills training;
- Meeting of labour market demands by strategic partnerships of training providers with labour market actors in the development of training programmes;
- Contribution to certification of microcredentials;
- Improved communication of science to the public, to make research careers more appealing to younger generations.

Scope: Skills are of utmost importance for researchers, they allow them to perform high quality research, and to make the overall European R&I system competitive and challenges-

proof. However, it is crucial that researchers are equipped not only with research-specific skills, but also with transversal skills that allow them to be interoperable between academia and the other sectors, including industry and business, and to be capable to establish entrepreneurial activities to turn innovative ideas into business and lead to social, environmental and economic profitability.

Being equipped with a wide spectrum of skills is of high benefit for researchers, who can have access to an enlarged number of opportunities for career development compared to the limited ones available in academia, but also for the labour market, which is in constant need for highly skilled talents such as researchers.

To support inter-sectoral mobility and a broad recognition of the research profession in academia and beyond, and in line with the Skills Agenda, the Commission has developed a set of skills and occupations relevant for researchers which contributed to the update of the European Skills, Competences and Occupations (ESCO) classification. It has also finalised a European Competence Framework for Researchers (ResearchComp)¹¹², which contains the competences that researchers should have for a successful and interoperable career in academia and beyond, including via entrepreneurship creation and through effective communication of science to the public, to engage an increasing number of young people in research careers. ResearchComp is divided into 7 competence areas, and for each competence it provides four progression levels, each of them with a number of foreseen learning outcomes.

Projects are expected to support research performing organisations in adapting and reinforcing formal and targeted training for researchers based on:

- The use of ResearchComp, so that training is provided not only on research-specific skills, but also on transversal skills that can foster better research careers in academia and beyond;
- Strategic interaction with ecosystem actors, in order to have a better understanding of labour market needs, close the gap between demand and supply, and jointly develop training programmes;
- The promotion and support for networking and the exchange of best practices between Higher Education Institutions and other training providers with regard to the development of formal and targeted training opportunities for researchers that can foster inter-sectoral and inter-disciplinary mobility;

¹¹² ResearchComp has been developed in line with the new ERA Communication and the Skills Agenda to strengthen researchers skills for successful careers in academia and beyond. The conceptual model of the framework includes 38 skills, divided in 7 competence areas (Cognitive abilities, Doing research, Managing research, Managing research tools, Making an impact, Working with others, Self-management). Each stakeholder will be able to use the framework according to its own needs. The final version of ResearchComp, to be rolled out by the end of 2022, will also include learning outcomes for each of the relevant skills. More information can be found in the policy brief “Knowledge ecosystems in the new ERA: Using a competence-based approach for career development in academia and beyond” <https://op.europa.eu/en/publication-detail/-/publication/8d536780-3025-11ed-975d-01aa75ed71a1/language-en>